



How to Boost Your Creativity

Just as exercise builds muscles and improves cardiovascular fitness, there are activities that can improve your creative conditioning by getting areas of the brain to work together in new ways.

To boost creativity, you must first remove barriers to it. Stress, time constraints, and lack of sleep or exercise are known creativity killers. People tend to be creative when they are rested, happy, and can let their thoughts wander freely. Many people claim to have their best ideas during their morning shower or walk to work. It seems that ideas flow most freely around our brains when they are not in a task-orientated state but instead in a condition called the resting state.

Cultivate new connections

Routines help regulate our daily lives, but they also reinforce existing neural pathways.

Creativity-friendly activities create new neural connections. Learning to play a musical instrument, for example, opens and strengthens links between different brain areas.

Simply varying your routine can also foster creativity, so pick a more interesting route to work, a color you don't usually wear, or a new recipe to cook. Surround yourself with like-minded, creative people as much as possible. Whether it is in a gallery or a garden shed, new input stimulates new ideas.

Unsolvable challenges encourage novel ways of thought. How many things can you think of to do with a paper clip, for instance? If you are stuck on a problem, get some

mental distance from it. Imagine how someone from another country, time period, or age group would deal with the issue.

Allow yourself to disconnect. If you are stuck in a line, don't default to your phone to check emails or social media; instead, zone out and let the ideas flow.

The next time you are stuck for ideas, try one of the following:

- **Get enough rest, destress, and exercise.**
- **Learn a new skill. Spend time with other creative people.**
- **Think outside the box. Think of new ways to solve old problems.**
- **Switch off from digital devices to give your brain some downtime.**